

MATH 551: NUMERICAL ORDINARY DIFFERENTIAL EQUATIONS

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1. AUGUST 24, 2026

1.1. **Ordinary differential equations.** An ODE has the form

$$x'(t) = f(t, x(t)).$$

Given an initial condition $x(t_0) = x_0$, the corresponding *initial-value problem* (IVP) is to find $x(t)$ for $t \geq t_0$ such that

$$(1) \quad x'(t) = f(t, x(t)), \quad x(t_0) = x_0.$$

Topics arising in the numerical solution of differential equations include

- non-stiff problems and stiff solvers;

- geometric solvers;
- parameter estimation and Bayesian approaches, where the vector field may depend on a model parameter θ , as in $f(t, x, \theta)$;
- boundary-value problems; and
- stochastic differential equations (SDEs).

We generally consider vector-valued solutions and vector fields,

$$x: \mathbb{R} \longrightarrow \mathbb{R}^n, \quad f: \mathbb{R} \times \mathbb{R}^n \longrightarrow \mathbb{R}^n,$$

which can be written componentwise as

$$x = \begin{bmatrix} x_1 \\ \vdots \\ x_n \end{bmatrix}, \quad f(t, x) = \begin{bmatrix} f_1(t, x_1, \dots, x_n) \\ \vdots \\ f_n(t, x_1, \dots, x_n) \end{bmatrix}.$$

1.2. Examples.

Example 1. *The scalar equation*

$$x' = x$$

is an ODE with $n = 1$.

Example 2 (Damped oscillator). *Consider the second-order equation*

$$x'' = -\omega^2 x - x'.$$

Setting $x_1 = x$ and $x_2 = x'$ converts it into the first-order system

$$\begin{cases} x_1' = x_2, \\ x_2' = -\omega^2 x_1 - x_2. \end{cases}$$

Thus, with $\mathbf{x} = (x_1, x_2)^\top$, we have $\mathbf{x}' = \mathbf{f}(x_1, x_2)$.

Example 3 (Chemical kinetics). *A three-species kinetic model is*

$$\mathbf{x} = \begin{bmatrix} x_1 \\ x_2 \\ x_3 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \begin{cases} x_1' = -k_1 x_1 + k_2 x_2 x_3, \\ x_2' = k_1 x_1 - k_2 x_2 x_3 - k_3 x_2^2, \\ x_3' = k_3 x_2^2, \end{cases}$$

where $k_1, k_2, k_3 > 0$ are reaction rates. The reaction rates may occur on very different scales, which can lead to stiffness.

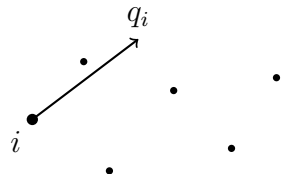
Example 4 (Molecular model). *Let q_i be the position of particle i , let m_i be its mass, and let $V(q_1, \dots, q_N)$ be the potential energy. Newton's equation is*

$$m_i q_i'' = -\frac{\partial V(q_1, \dots, q_N)}{\partial q_i}.$$

Introducing the momentum $p_i = m_i q_i'$ gives

$$\begin{cases} q_i' = \frac{p_i}{m_i}, \\ p_i' = -\frac{\partial V}{\partial q_i}. \end{cases}$$

The positions and momenta can therefore be collected into the state vector

$$\mathbf{x} = \begin{bmatrix} q_1 \\ p_1 \\ q_2 \\ p_2 \\ \vdots \\ q_N \\ p_N \end{bmatrix}.$$


1.3. Solutions and the Lipschitz condition. Consider the IVP (1) on an interval containing t_0 .

Definition 1. *A function $x(t)$ is a solution of the IVP if it satisfies the integral equation*

$$x(t) = x_0 + \int_{t_0}^t f(s, x(s)) ds.$$

Definition 2 (Lipschitz condition). *The vector field f is Lipschitz continuous in x on a domain D if there is a constant $L \geq 0$ such that*

$$\|f(t, x) - f(t, y)\| \leq L\|x - y\|$$

for all $x, y \in D$ and all relevant t .

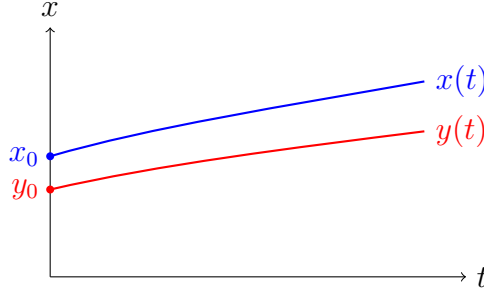
Under the usual continuity assumption in t , the Lipschitz condition in x implies that the solution of the IVP exists and is unique on an appropriate interval.

The same condition also controls the sensitivity to the initial data. Let $x(t)$ and $y(t)$ be solutions with initial values x_0 and y_0 , respectively. Their integral equations give

$$\begin{aligned} \|x(t) - y(t)\| &\leq \|x_0 - y_0\| + \int_{t_0}^t \|f(s, x(s)) - f(s, y(s))\| ds \\ &\leq \|x_0 - y_0\| + L \int_{t_0}^t \|x(s) - y(s)\| ds. \end{aligned}$$

By Grönwall's inequality,

$$(2) \quad \|x(t) - y(t)\| \leq \|x_0 - y_0\| e^{L(t-t_0)}.$$



Thus nearby initial values produce solutions whose separation is bounded by (2).

2. AUGUST 26, 2026

The main topics are properties of solutions, time discretization, and consistency error. We continue to consider the IVP

$$(3) \quad x'(t) = f(t, x(t)), \quad x(t_0) = x_0,$$

where $x: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$.

2.1. Stability of solutions. The integral formulation of (3) is

$$x(t) = x_0 + \int_{t_0}^t f(s, x(s)) ds.$$

If $y(t)$ is another solution with initial value y_0 , then

$$y(t) = y_0 + \int_{t_0}^t f(s, y(s)) ds,$$

and hence

$$y(t) - x(t) = y_0 - x_0 + \int_{t_0}^t (f(s, y(s)) - f(s, x(s))) ds.$$

Suppose f is Lipschitz continuous in x with Lipschitz constant L , so that

$$\|f(t, y) - f(t, x)\| \leq L\|y - x\|.$$

Taking norms gives

$$(4) \quad \|y(t) - x(t)\| \leq \|y_0 - x_0\| + \int_{t_0}^t L\|y(s) - x(s)\| ds.$$

The following inequality controls this accumulation of error.

Lemma 1 (Grönwall's inequality). *Let $u, v \in C([t_0, t_1], \mathbb{R})$ be nonnegative functions and let $\rho \geq 0$. If*

$$(5) \quad u(t) \leq \rho + \int_{t_0}^t v(s)u(s) ds, \quad t \in [t_0, t_1],$$

then

$$(6) \quad u(t) \leq \rho \exp \left(\int_{t_0}^t v(s) ds \right), \quad t \in [t_0, t_1].$$

In particular, $u \equiv 0$ when $\rho = 0$.

Proof. First suppose that $\rho > 0$ and define

$$U(t) = \rho + \int_{t_0}^t v(s)u(s) ds.$$

Then $U \in C^1([t_0, t_1], \mathbb{R})$, and

$$u(t) \leq U(t), \quad U(t) \geq \rho > 0.$$

Since u and v are nonnegative,

$$U'(t) = v(t)u(t) \leq v(t)U(t).$$

Thus the logarithmic derivative of U satisfies

$$(\log U(t))' = \frac{U'(t)}{U(t)} \leq v(t).$$

Integrating from t_0 to t yields

$$\log U(t) - \log U(t_0) \leq \int_{t_0}^t v(s) ds.$$

Because $U(t_0) = \rho$ and $u(t) \leq U(t)$, applying the exponential function proves (6) when $\rho > 0$.

Now suppose that $\rho = 0$. For any $\varepsilon > 0$, (5) implies

$$u(t) \leq \varepsilon + \int_{t_0}^t v(s)u(s) ds.$$

The first part of the proof, with $\rho = \varepsilon$, gives

$$0 \leq u(t) \leq \varepsilon \exp \left(\int_{t_0}^t v(s) ds \right).$$

Letting $\varepsilon \downarrow 0$ shows that $u(t) = 0$ for every $t \in [t_0, t_1]$. $\square$

Apply Lemma 1 to (4) with

$$u(t) = \|y(t) - x(t)\|, \quad v(t) = L, \quad \rho = \|y_0 - x_0\|.$$

We obtain

$$(7) \quad \|y(t) - x(t)\| \leq \|y_0 - x_0\| e^{L(t-t_0)}.$$

This estimate can be pessimistic, but it establishes continuous dependence on the initial data.

2.2. The solution map. The *solution map*, or *flow map*, is denoted by

$$x(t) = \varphi^{t,t_0}(x_0).$$

For example, consider the scalar logistic equation

$$x' = x(1 - x).$$

For $x_0 \neq 0$, its solution is

$$\varphi^{t,t_0}(x_0) = \frac{1}{1 + \frac{1-x_0}{x_0}e^{-(t-t_0)}}.$$

When $x_0 = 0$, the solution is $x(t) \equiv 0$.

The solution map has the identity and composition properties

$$\begin{aligned}\varphi^{t_0,t_0}(x_0) &= x_0, & \varphi^{t_0,t_0} &= I, \\ \varphi^{t_2,t_1}(\varphi^{t_1,t_0}(x_0)) &= \varphi^{t_2,t_0}(x_0).\end{aligned}$$

The second property is the basis of time marching.

Differentiating the solution map with respect to time gives

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{d}{dt}\varphi^{t,t_0}(x_0) &= f(t, x(t)), \\ \frac{d^2}{dt^2}\varphi^{t,t_0}(x_0) &= f_t(t, x(t)) + f_x(t, x(t))x'(t) \\ &= (f_t + f_x f)(t, x(t)),\end{aligned}$$

where f_x is the Jacobian matrix of f with respect to x . Higher time derivatives can be found by repeated differentiation, for example with automatic differentiation; they can also be viewed through the Koopman operator.

To measure sensitivity with respect to the initial value, define the Wronskian matrix

$$W(t) = \frac{\partial}{\partial x_0}\varphi^{t,t_0}(x_0) = \frac{\partial x(t)}{\partial x_0}.$$

Differentiating with respect to t gives

$$\begin{aligned}W'(t) &= \frac{\partial}{\partial x_0}f(t, x(t)) \\ &= f_x(t, x(t))\frac{\partial x(t)}{\partial x_0}.\end{aligned}$$

Thus, if

$$A(t) = f_x(t, x(t)),$$

then W satisfies the *variational equation*

$$(8) \quad W'(t) = A(t)W(t), \quad W(t_0) = I.$$

2.3. One-step methods. Choose a time grid

$$t_0 < t_1 < \cdots < t_N = t, \quad \tau_j = t_{j+1} - t_j,$$

where the step sizes τ_j are small. Repeated use of the composition property gives

$$\varphi^{t_N, t_0} = \varphi^{t_N, t_{N-1}} \circ \cdots \circ \varphi^{t_2, t_1} \circ \varphi^{t_1, t_0}.$$

It is therefore enough to approximate a single short-time solution map. Writing $t_j = t$ and $t_{j+1} = t + \tau$, Taylor expansion gives

$$(9) \quad \varphi^{t+\tau, t}(x) = x + \tau f(t, x) + \frac{\tau^2}{2} (f_t + f_x f)(t, x) + O(\tau^3).$$

Dropping the terms of order τ^2 and higher defines the Euler one-step map

$$\Psi^{t+\tau, t}(x) = x + \tau f(t, x).$$

Consequently, Euler's method is

$$(10) \quad x_{j+1} = x_j + \tau_j f(t_j, x_j).$$

Its one-step consistency error follows from (9):

$$\varphi^{t+\tau, t}(x) - \Psi^{t+\tau, t}(x) = \frac{\tau^2}{2} (f_t + f_x f)(t, x) + O(\tau^3) = O(\tau^2).$$

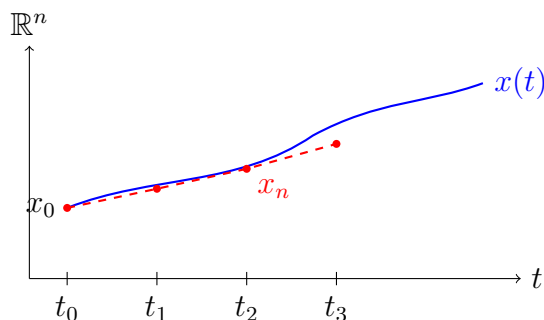
3. AUGUST 28, 2026

We continue the study of one-step methods, focusing on consistency, examples, and convergence. Let

$$t_0 < t_1 < \cdots < t_N, \quad \tau_n = t_{n+1} - t_n,$$

where t_n is a time level and τ_n is the corresponding step size. We use $x(t_n)$ for the exact solution and x_n for its numerical approximation:

$$x(t_n) \approx x_n.$$



A one-step method advances the numerical solution by a map

$$(11) \quad x_{n+1} = \Psi^{t_{n+1}, t_n}(x_n).$$

Thus the exact and numerical solutions at t_n can be written as

$$\begin{aligned} x(t_n) &= \varphi^{t_n, t_{n-1}} \circ \dots \circ \varphi^{t_2, t_1} \circ \varphi^{t_1, t_0}(x_0), \\ x_n &= \Psi^{t_n, t_{n-1}} \circ \dots \circ \Psi^{t_2, t_1} \circ \Psi^{t_1, t_0}(x_0). \end{aligned}$$

3.1. Methods obtained from quadrature. The integral form of the ODE over one step is

$$(12) \quad x(t_{n+1}) = x(t_n) + \int_{t_n}^{t_{n+1}} f(s, x(s)) ds.$$

Different quadrature approximations of this integral produce different one-step methods.

3.1.1. Forward Euler method. Using the left endpoint in (12) gives

$$x(t_{n+1}) \approx x(t_n) + \tau_n f(t_n, x(t_n)).$$

Replacing the exact solution values by numerical approximations yields

$$(13) \quad x_{n+1} = x_n + \tau_n f(t_n, x_n) = \Psi_{\text{FE}}^{t_{n+1}, t_n}(x_n).$$

3.1.2. Backward Euler method. Using the right endpoint instead gives

$$x(t_{n+1}) \approx x(t_n) + \tau_n f(t_{n+1}, x(t_{n+1})).$$

The resulting method is

$$(14) \quad x_{n+1} = x_n + \tau_n f(t_{n+1}, x_{n+1}) = \Psi_{\text{BE}}^{t_{n+1}, t_n}(x_n).$$

Because x_{n+1} occurs on both sides, backward Euler requires the solution of a fixed-point problem at each step.

3.1.3. *A predictor–corrector method.* The trapezoidal rule suggests

$$x(t_{n+1}) \approx x(t_n) + \frac{\tau_n}{2} (f(t_n, x(t_n)) + f(t_{n+1}, x(t_{n+1}))).$$

We can first predict the right endpoint with forward Euler and then use that prediction in the trapezoidal formula:

$$(15) \quad x_{n+1}^* = x_n + \tau_n f(t_n, x_n),$$

$$(16) \quad x_{n+1} = x_n + \frac{\tau_n}{2} (f(t_n, x_n) + f(t_{n+1}, x_{n+1}^*)).$$

This explicit two-stage scheme is also called Heun’s method. Together, the two stages define a one-step map

$$x_{n+1} = \Psi_H^{t_{n+1}, t_n}(x_n).$$

3.2. **Local consistency error.** For a numerical one-step map Ψ , define its *local error*, or *consistency error*, at (t_n, x) by

$$(17) \quad \mathcal{E}_n(x) = \varphi^{t_{n+1}, t_n}(x) - \Psi^{t_{n+1}, t_n}(x).$$

Here the exact and numerical steps start from the same value x at time t_n .

Example 5 (Forward Euler). *The Taylor expansion from (9) gives*

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{E}_n^{\text{FE}}(x) &= \varphi^{t_n + \tau_n, t_n}(x) - (x + \tau_n f(t_n, x)) \\ &= \frac{\tau_n^2}{2} (f_t + f_x f)(t_n, x) + O(\tau_n^3) \\ &= O(\tau_n^2). \end{aligned}$$

Example 6 (Backward Euler). *Let*

$$y(\tau) = \Psi_{\text{BE}}^{t_n + \tau, t_n}(x).$$

The defining fixed-point equation is

$$y(\tau) = x + \tau f(t_n + \tau, y(\tau)).$$

Differentiating this equation and evaluating at $\tau = 0$ gives

$$y'(0) = f(t_n, x), \quad y''(0) = 2(f_t + f_x f)(t_n, x).$$

Therefore,

$$\Psi_{\text{BE}}^{t_n+\tau_n, t_n}(x) = x + \tau_n f(t_n, x) + \tau_n^2 (f_t + f_x f)(t_n, x) + O(\tau_n^3).$$

Comparing this with the exact flow expansion yields

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{E}_n^{\text{BE}}(x) &= -\frac{\tau_n^2}{2} (f_t + f_x f)(t_n, x) + O(\tau_n^3) \\ &= O(\tau_n^2). \end{aligned}$$

3.3. Global error and convergence. The *global error* at t_n is

$$(18) \quad e_n = x_n - x(t_n).$$

The local errors accumulate as the method marches forward in time. On a fixed time interval there are approximately $1/\tau$ steps of size τ , so one generally loses one power of τ when passing from local to global error:

$$\mathcal{E}_n = O(\tau^{p+1}) \implies e_n = O(\tau^p).$$

More generally, with

$$h = \max_{0 \leq n < N} \tau_n,$$

a stable one-step method with local error $O(h^{p+1})$ has global error $O(h^p)$ under the usual smoothness assumptions. Thus both forward and backward Euler have local error of order two and global order one.